

Chapter 53-1

The evening after the rain had just cleared still carried a hint of chill. The wind, though not as unrestrained as during the rain, still rolled up fragile leaves in spirals, sending them dancing away into the distance.

In the distance, orange-red clouds scattered across the sky's edge, and the cold sun was tinted red, as if foretelling tomorrow's good weather.

Qi Jiao wore a blue fitted long dress with a black coat over it that didn't match her temperament. The sleeves were so long they covered her hands. Sitting in the passenger seat, she said gently, "Just stop at the next intersection. I'll walk back by myself."

"How can that be?" The driver gripped the steering wheel with one hand while holding her hand with the other, bringing it to her lips for a kiss before smiling. "I can't bear to let my baby walk such a long way."

"Cheng Ran." Qi Jiao frowned slightly. "Just at that intersection."

"Let's go a bit further." Cheng Ran said, easily passing that intersection.

Qi Jiao became anxious, her coquettish tone carrying a hint of urgency. "Cheng Ran~!"

But Cheng Ran just laughed softly. "What is my baby worried about? Am I not presentable?"

"No." Qi Jiao lowered her eyes, pulling her hand from Cheng Ran's palm in silent protest.

Cheng Ran glanced at her, the empty hand losing some of its warmth.

The blue sports car suddenly braked after speeding, tires screeching against the ground as it stopped by the roadside.

Qi Jiao took off the coat that didn't belong to her, folding it neatly and placing it on her lap. Her voice was gentle but somewhat distant: "I'm leaving first. Drive slowly on your way home."

She was about to pull the car door handle when Cheng Ran grabbed her wrist. "Just leaving like that?"

Qi Jiao looked up slightly, those deer-like eyes staring at Cheng Ran with a hint of grievance, as if reproaching her earlier disobedience.

"I have to go home." Qi Jiao knew what she wanted, but she was in a bad mood and didn't want to cooperate.

Cheng Ran smiled coldly. "Angry?"

Qi Jiao replied, "No."

"Then why do you have that expression?" Cheng Ran scoffed. "You're clearly still angry."

"Really, I'm not." Qi Jiao pried away the hand gripping her wrist, saying coldly, "I have to go home."

With that, she opened the car door and got out.

The wind lifted her long dress, and the low temperature made her exposed skin break out in fine goosebumps.

Before she could walk away from the car, the driver's door opened.

Cheng Ran got out of the car, taking quick steps to drape the coat over her shoulders.

Qi Jiao turned back in surprise, wanting to take it off and refuse it. If her mother saw her wearing someone else's coat...

The consequences would be unthinkable.

Cheng Ran pressed down on her shoulders. "Just say it's a friend's, or I won't let you go."

Qi Jiao bit her lip, still afraid.

Cheng Ran moved close to her, easily pressing her against the front of the car.

Qi Jiao's body leaned against the car's front, the cold metal penetrating through her back muscles, chilling her to the bone.

She couldn't help but shiver.

But Cheng Ran's body pressed against her, one hand around Qi Jiao's waist while the other lingered on her thigh.

Even through the dress, she could easily touch Qi Jiao's most sensitive places.

Cheng Ran's lips moved near her ear. "Jiao Jiao¹, what do you still owe me?"

Half of Qi Jiao's body went weak, but she still retained some rationality, placing one hand on Cheng Ran's shoulder. "Don't... we're outside."

Cheng Ran chuckled softly. "Good Jiao Jiao, tell me, what do you still owe me?"

Qi Jiao bit her lip, her tongue moistening her lips before a kiss with moisture landed on Cheng Ran's cheek.

Cheng Ran laughed lowly, her voice carrying a hint of huskiness, as if deliberately teasing her. Her hand pinched Qi Jiao's waist with punitive intent. "Just that?"

Qi Jiao pushed her. "I really have to go home."

"What should I do? You haven't even left yet, and I'm already missing you." Cheng Ran's body pressed closer, becoming the only source of warmth for Qi Jiao in the cold wind.

But Qi Jiao hadn't forgotten the agreement to be home punctually at seven o'clock.

If she was even a minute late...

Qi Jiao didn't dare think about the consequences.

She pushed Cheng Ran, pleading in a low voice, "Cheng Ran, not today."

"Just one kiss." Cheng Ran said, moving closer as a passionate kiss was already falling upon her.

As the sun set in the west, the evening glow scattered across the horizon.

Qi Jiao's slender back felt the car's cold temperature, while her soft front felt the Alpha's continuous warmth.

Cheng Ran was used to being wild; whether in kissing technique or in bed, she was very skilled.

As long as she was willing, she could make someone very comfortable.

First-time girlfriend Qi Jiao was no match for her at all.

If Cheng Ran deliberately tried to seduce someone, Qi Jiao could only retreat step by step, begging for mercy.

Qi Jiao had to restrain herself to avoid making strange sounds.

But Cheng Ran had a wicked sense of humor. In broad daylight, she whispered in her ear, "Good Jiao Jiao, cry out."

Qi Jiao's eyes were misty, bullied to the point of physiological tears, her whole body as soft as cotton.

The gentle girl was like a pool of water, making Cheng Ran's desire swell as she coaxed softly, "Good Jiao Jiao, don't go back tonight."

Qi Jiao shook her head. "I can't."

Footnotes:

1. **Jiao Jiao**: An affectionate diminutive of Qi Jiao's name, adding intimacy to the address.

Chapter 53-2

The sunset was an extremely rapid process. Soon the streetlights came on, illuminating the world in an instant.

Fear flashed through Qi Jiao's heart as she used all her strength to push Cheng Ran away. "I really have to go."

Having already been aroused, Cheng Ran's eyes flashed with impatience, but looking at Qi Jiao's delicate face, she quickly restrained her aggression.

She reached out to wipe near Qi Jiao's mouth, her thumb gently caressing the tender skin, taking away a trace of moisture, then pulled out a wet tissue to gently clean her fingers.

Cheng Ran also helped Qi Jiao tidy up her scattered hair, pulling up the loose coat and even zipping it up.

She patted her on the head. "Be good, just say it's a friend's."

Qi Jiao, weakened by her teasing, bit her lip and immediately turned to run away.

Cheng Ran watched her retreating figure, taking a cigarette from her pocket, holding it between her fingers and lighting it.

The crimson glow scattered in the night, and the fire suppressed in her heart finally dissipated somewhat.

However, hadn't she been playing with this woman for quite a while now?

As she was thinking, her phone rang.

She glanced at the screen and answered, her voice carrying unsatisfied hoarseness and impatience. "What is it?"

"A girl who just came back." The other party sounded excited. "Sister Ran¹, saved you the youngest one."

"Is she of age?" Cheng Ran asked, taking a drag of her cigarette.

The other party laughed. "Of course she is. She's the same type as the one you've been liking recently, very fresh and beautiful."

Cheng Ran looked in the direction where Qi Jiao had left, a thought of refusal flashing through her mind, but the other party laughed. "Sister Ran? Settling down?"

Cheng Ran extinguished the half-smoked cigarette, lightly exhaling a puff of smoke as that suppressed desire appeared again. Her voice was indifferent as she said, "Send her to the upstairs room, make her wash clean."

"Don't worry." The other party said, "For Sister Ran to play with, how could she not be clean? She's still a virgin too."

Cheng Ran said nothing and hung up.

On the other side, Qi Jiao looked at her phone—it was already 18:58.

Thinking of the situation she might face when she got home, she quickened her pace, but having been bullied too harshly by Cheng Ran just now, she had no strength left.

She ran frantically for a few steps, her blue long dress flying in the night.

Running until she was gasping for breath, she finally reached the front gate at 59 seconds. Before she could celebrate, she looked up and saw the woman wearing a water-green qipao².

Yang Jiani stood at the doorway, dim yellow light falling on her.

Though it was clearly early autumn, she was dressed lightly, holding a Republic-era style fan in her hand.

Her gaze fell upon Qi Jiao, who felt a bone-chilling coldness, her footsteps seeming nailed to the spot.

Yang Jiani glanced in the direction from which Qi Jiao had just run, speaking unhurriedly. "Who was that person?"

Qi Jiao's heart tightened, swallowing hard as she fearfully called out, "Mom."

"Whose coat are you wearing again?" Yang Jiani calmly looked her over, her gaze falling on the black coat she was wearing. Frightened, Qi Jiao shivered and immediately began taking off the coat.

But her fingers were trembling, and while pulling the zipper, she accidentally caught her fingertip flesh in it.

The pain made her gasp.

Her finger was bleeding, but she dared not delay even slightly, immediately taking off the coat and throwing it on the ground.

She nervously answered, "A... a friend's."

Yang Jiani closed the fan in her hand, smiling slightly. "Qi Jiao, are you lying to me?"

Qi Jiao shook her head. "No..."

But this "no" was said very weakly.

"Qi Jiao, you know what punishment liars receive, don't you?" Yang Jiani leaned against the wall, appearing entirely languid, but Qi Jiao knew that this version of her was the most terrifying.

Qi Jiao closed her eyes, a tear falling. "I'm sorry."

"Who wants to hear your apology?" Yang Jiani laughed. "You're in love? With whom?"

Qi Jiao's hand hanging at her side clenched into a fist, nervously answering, "It's... someone I... met... on the road before."

"Which road?" Yang Jiani asked. "When did this happen?"

Qi Jiao: "..."

She stammered out the story of meeting Cheng Ran.

But Yang Jiani extracted key information from her words, raising an eyebrow slightly. "Chengqiang Road³? That's the road to Angel Orphanage. Who were you thinking of?"

Qi Jiao shrank her shoulders. "No, the kindergarten organized a staff activity, we went to Loving Care Nursing Home."

"So what did you remember there?" Yang Jiani looked at her, her voice suddenly becoming mournful. "Jiao Jiao."

Indescribable fear rose from the bottom of her heart.

Even though she had been Qi Jiao for many years, she still couldn't get used to it.

Yang Jiani straightened up, opening the villa's front door. "Come in."

Qi Jiao dragged her two stiff legs forward, knowing tonight was destined to be sleepless.

As Yang Jiani led her into the villa, she said gently, "Lying, falling in love, and letting someone touch your body—Qi Jiao, you know what you should do, don't you?"

Though her voice was gentle, Qi Jiao felt like she was hearing a vengeful ghost demanding her life.

She closed her eyes and answered despairingly, "I know."

Footnotes:

1. **Sister Ran:** A respectful way to address an older woman or someone in a position of authority, showing deference in Chinese culture.
2. **Qipao:** A traditional Chinese dress, also known as cheongsam, characterized by a high collar and fitted silhouette.
3. **Chengqiang Road:** A street name. Chinese addresses often use directional or descriptive terms; "cheng" (城) means city/wall and "qiang" (墙) means wall.

Chapter 53-3

Walking through the first floor corridor and opening the door at the very edge, there was a staircase leading to the basement.

Qi Jiao descended the stairs step by step. Before even entering the basement, she could already feel the sinister cold.

She raised her pale, thin hand and gently pushed open the heavy door.

Inside and outside the door were two different worlds.

Inside the door was pitch black. Even when the lights were turned on, there was only weak illumination.

Not even as bright as the momentary glow when a phone screen lit up.

The basement was dark and damp, even carrying a musty smell.

Various types of whips hung on the walls.

In the middle of the room, there was a rectangular contraption made of pebbles.

Qi Jiao walked in first, with Yang Jiani following closely behind. After she entered, she closed the door.

As if draining away all of Qi Jiao's hope.

Yang Jiani took the most handy whip from the wall, then said in a low voice, "Qi Jiao, kneel down."

Qi Jiao knelt on the area covered with pebbles, her knees pressed until they felt like they would shatter.

"Do you know your mistake?" Yang Jiani stood not far behind her, but in the darkness it was impossible to discern her position. Her voice was also very cold, merging with the basement. "How dare you?"

Qi Jiao bit her lip. "I'm sorry."

"Where did she touch you?" Yang Jiani asked.

Qi Jiao remained silent.

"Not going to say?" Yang Jiani asked again.

Qi Jiao only had that one phrase left: "I'm sorry."

Yang Jiani laughed coldly. "You really do like her. If my Jiao Jiao were still here, would she be dating now too?"

Qi Jiao pressed her lips together. "I'm sorry."

"My Jiao Jiao never said 'I'm sorry.'" Yang Jiani's voice became increasingly eerie, accompanied by low laughter. "My Jiao Jiao liked to say: 'Mommy, I was wrong.'"

Qi Jiao frowned, saying in a low voice, "Mommy, I was wrong."

"Wrong tone." Yang Jiani said, and with that, a whip struck Qi Jiao's back with fierce wind.

"..."

Qi Jiao closed her eyes, feeling the seemingly endless pain.

These days filled with agony—

When would they end?

Could one only find release by doing what she¹ did?

But then someone else would have to bear this suffering, wouldn't they?

Would these days ever end?

Footnotes:

1. **She:** This likely refers to another person who found "release" from similar suffering, possibly through death or escape, though the exact reference is ambiguous in this context.

Chapter 53-4

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The Japanese-style decorated private room remained silent for a long time.

Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi's gazes met, both discovering incredulous emotions in each other's eyes.

There was even a hint of eeriness and fear.

Because Zhao Ying had an appointment to play golf in the afternoon, Liang Shi wandered around alone after eating with her.

Later, finding herself unable to focus on shopping, she locked herself in her car, thinking about this problem while waiting for Xu Qingzhu.

She had thought about it all afternoon but couldn't figure it out.

It was probably because Mrs. Qi's oppressive presence was too strong, suppressing her entire train of thought. All the information points in her mind were like a tangled mess, and she couldn't find where the thread began.

Several times she felt she was about to find it, but to no avail.

When she met Xu Qingzhu in the evening, she was still not in the right state—she could even forget to pay when buying bubble tea.

Fortunately, Xu Qingzhu was following behind her, avoiding the embarrassment of being called back to pay in the crowd.

With some time before the concert started, the two decided to eat at a Japanese restaurant.

After entering the private room, Liang Shi meticulously recounted the entire process of encountering Mrs. Qi that morning.

There was no choice—it was too bizarre.

Her subjective emotions were too intense, causing her to lose objective thinking.

But unexpectedly, Xu Qingzhu immediately discovered the most important point, and when both spoke that word in unison, they both fell silent.

Why would Mrs. Qi say she had lost a daughter before?

After the silence, Xu Qingzhu drank some bubble tea, trying to apply logic to this matter. "I asked Zhao Xuning before, and she said Qi Jiao jumped off a building once during her third year of middle school¹, and afterwards she disappeared like she had vanished. So could she be referring to that incident? In her heart, Qi Jiao had died once."

But Liang Shi's thinking was completely opened up by that word "again."

After Xu Qingzhu proposed this possibility, she slowly shook her head. "It doesn't seem likely."

The afternoon's confusion seemed to find an outlet at this moment, and the tangled mess in her mind began to become clear.

After a long while, Liang Shi said gently, "When she was talking to me, she mentioned two different ways of addressing her—one was Qi Jiao, and the other was 'my Jiao Jiao.' When she called out 'my Jiao Jiao,' her tone was tender and lingering, as if she were missing someone who could never return."

"Right." Xu Qingzhu pulled the threads from her memory, also remembering the first time she met Mrs. Qi.

At that time, she had also said, "She looks so much like our Jiao Jiao."

Her tone was exactly as Liang Shi described—gentle, lingering, and tinged with nostalgia.

"But when she talked about Qi Jiao, she showed no emotion." Liang Shi said. "And I feel she has an extremely strong desire to control Qi Jiao. She knew I had gone to find Qi Jiao and warned me not to look for her again."

"What is she afraid we'll discover?" Xu Qingzhu asked in confusion.

Liang Shi shook her head. "That's unclear. Before..."

She suddenly stopped.

Just then, a server came in to serve a dish, and she remained deep in thought.

After the server left, Xu Qingzhu asked, "What happened?"

"When I went to find Qi Jiao last time, she said to me—'If I tell you, Qi Jiao has already...'" Liang Shi said. "She only said this half sentence, then stopped. What could follow that?"

"Gone crazy? Died? Been killed?" Xu Qingzhu frowned. "But isn't the current Qi Jiao the same person as before?"

"Not certain." Liang Shi said. "But from the photos, it's the same face."

"But I don't understand." Xu Qingzhu said. "If your mom—the one from the Liang family—if she wanted to abuse you, couldn't she do it herself? Why throw you to Yang Jiani?"

Liang Shi bit her lip with a bitter smile. "She probably still wanted to be a good mother in front of her children."

So she used someone else to do her dirty work².

She couldn't understand Qiu Zimin either.

In her view, Qiu Zimin's behavior was very much like that of a madwoman.

Madpeople couldn't be understood by ordinary people, and one should never try to enter a madperson's inner world or think from a madperson's perspective—doing so might turn you into the next madperson.

Liang Shi felt that many questions about Mrs. Qi still needed to be asked of Qi Jiao.

But she couldn't bear to pour salt on that gentle girl's wounds.

She had been so frightened at the film set today, let alone Qi Jiao who had been experiencing those things all along.

But if she didn't ask, would Qi Jiao be better off?

She really wanted to avenge her childhood.

All domestic violence should go to hell.

Because she was thinking about this matter, Liang Shi ate the entire meal absent-mindedly.

Xu Qingzhu also noticed something was wrong with her mood, so after finishing the meal, she proactively said, "Why don't we just go straight home? We can listen to the concert another time and go back to rest early."

Liang Shi panicked upon hearing this, immediately saying, "No need, I'm fine."

She still had to listen to the concert—she needed to complete her mission!

Moreover, the tickets were already bought.

She heard this was a world-class pianist, with tickets costing two thousand yuan each.

Liang Shi couldn't possibly waste four thousand yuan, even if she was preoccupied!

She answered too excitedly, startling even Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu asked in confusion, "Do you like her that much?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Well, not really.

This pianist didn't exist in Liang Shi's previous world, and Liang Shi's accomplishments in music were indeed not high—she often fell asleep listening to pure music.

It had the same effect as a poor student listening to English to fall asleep.

Facing Xu Qingzhu's question now, she coughed lightly. "It's alright."

So the two went to the concert hall.

1. **Third year of middle school:** In the Chinese education system, this refers to the final year of junior high school (around age 14-15), which is typically a high-stress period due to important entrance exams.
2. **Used someone else to do her dirty work:** The Chinese idiom "借刀殺人" literally means "borrow a knife to kill someone," referring to using another person as a tool to accomplish something harmful while keeping one's own hands clean.

Chapter 53-5

There were only a few minutes left before the concert began, and the concert hall was almost full.

Liang Shi had bought tickets early and got excellent seats. She led Xu Qingzhu to find their seats.

Liang Shi first settled Xu Qingzhu down, then went to the restroom. When she returned, the pianist was already seated at the piano, the lights in the concert hall dimmed, and Liang Shi, afraid of blocking the view of those behind her, bent over as she made her way to the inner seat.

Next to them was a couple who seemed to be having some issue—the woman was making a fuss about changing seats. Liang Shi listened in on their gossip.

Suddenly, some unknown force pushed her, and she lost her footing, falling straight backward.

Xu Qingzhu reached out to pull her up, and she ended up sitting directly on Xu Qingzhu's lap.

As luck would have it, she was too heavy.

The weight made Xu Qingzhu let out a muffled groan in the darkness.

Carrying some indescribable undertones.

Liang Shi swallowed hard, but her hands instinctively hooked around Xu Qingzhu's neck out of survival instinct, holding onto her.

The lights in the entire venue went out, and the piano music began at just the right moment.

Liang Shi's hand happened to intertwine with Xu Qingzhu's, transmitting moist heat through their palms.

Her heart was beating extremely fast—whether from fright or something else—but it was all drowned out by the piano music.

While she was lost in thought, Xu Qingzhu suddenly asked in a low voice, "Teacher Liang¹, are you sitting comfortably?"

Footnotes:

1. **Teacher Liang:** Xu Qingzhu uses a formal/teasing address here, as "老师" (teacher) can be used playfully between close acquaintances to create distance or tease someone, especially in situations with subtle romantic tension.